

FTC Awards & Advancement — Plain-English Guide

FIRST Tech Challenge · BIOBUZZ (2026–27) · for STEM4U families & coaches

This is an orientation, not the rulebook. Official award criteria live in the **FTC Competition Manual (\$6)**, and how many teams advance (and the exact points) are set by **FIRST Chesapeake** for our events. Award names, sponsors, and numbers can change each season — always confirm against the current manual and FIRST Chesapeake before you rely on them.

The awards — what each one recognizes

Award	What it recognizes	Type
Inspire	Top award — best all-around across robot (MCI), team (TA), and documentation.	Usually advances first
Think	How well the Engineering Portfolio documents the design journey.	Documentation
Design	Strong industrial / mechanical design and function.	MCI
Innovate	A creative, inventive element of the robot's design.	MCI
Control	Advanced software — sensors, autonomous, and control.	MCI
Connect	Building meaningful partnerships with the STEM community + a growth plan.	TA
Reach	Introducing and recruiting new people into FIRST (outreach).	TA
Sustain	A plan to keep the team going year to year.	TA
Judges' Choice	Something notable the judges want to recognize.	Discretionary
Winning / Finalist Alliance	On-field match results in the playoffs.	Performance
Dean's List	Outstanding individual student leaders.	Individual

Categories: **MCI** (Design · Innovate · Control) · **TA** (Connect · Reach · Sustain) · **Documentation** (Think). At most events only **one** of the three MCI and **one** of the three TA awards is given. Full criteria: FTC Competition Manual V1, Section 6.

How a team advances (the concept)

FTC runs through **qualifying tournaments → a regional / state championship → (super-regional / FIRST Championship)**, depending on the region. Advancing is **not just winning matches** — each event ranks teams on **advancement points** that blend three things:

- **Judged awards** — Inspire is the highest; award winners advance first.
- **Robot performance** — your qualification ranking from the matches.
- **Alliance selection & playoffs** — being picked and how far you go.

The Inspire Award winner typically advances first, then a mix of other award winners and top performers fill the remaining slots. **The number of advancing spots and the exact point values are set per event by FIRST Chesapeake** — confirm there.

The Engineering Portfolio — start day one

The Engineering Portfolio is the document your team submits to judges (often **before** the event) that tells the story of your season — who you are, how you engineered your robot, and how you've grown as a team. It's the first thing judges read, so it shapes the entire judging conversation. It directly drives the **Think** award and feeds **Inspire, Connect, Reach, Sustain, Design, Innovate, and Control**.

What goes in it

- **Team overview & goals** — who you are and your plan for the season.
- **Engineering / design process** — iterations, decisions, and testing; show what *failed* and what you changed.
- **Robot design highlights** — key mechanisms and *why*.
- **Strategy, business & sustainability plan** — funding, timeline, keeping the team going.
- **Outreach & community** (Connect / Reach / Sustain) — who you reached, partnerships, and keeping the team going.

STEM4U tips

- Assign a **Portfolio owner** (and a co-owner) on day one.
- **Document as you go** — photos, sketches, decisions, and data every meeting. Don't reconstruct it at the end.
- **Show the journey, not just the result** — judges reward iteration and reasoning.
- Keep it **readable** — clear headers, captions on images, plain language.
- Every kid should be able to **speak to a part of it** in the pit interview.

Portfolio limits (Manual V1): **max 15 pages** of content plus 1 cover page, US Letter, under 15 MB if digital, and only content **since Jan 1, 2026**. Check Team Updates for any changes.

What to prepare (this is where teams win)

- **Engineering Portfolio** — Your documented design journey — judges read it. Start day one and update every meeting.
- **Robot & code** — Build to score, but also to show off design and control for those awards.
- **Robot inspection** — Pass hardware + software inspection before you can play matches.
- **Judging / pit interview** — Every kid should be able to speak to their part of the robot and season.
- **Outreach (Connect / Reach / Sustain)** — Plan community engagement early — it's judged, not last-minute.
- **Control Award submission** — If you're going for Control, prepare the submission sheet ahead of the event.

Our season anchors

Kickoff / game reveal: Sat Sep 12, 2026. **Build & iterate:** Sep → Jan. **Regional:** FIRST Chesapeake (~Feb 2027). Confirm all dates on the FIRST Chesapeake site.

Orientation only, prepared for STEM4U — OtterBots · BadgerBots · WolfBots. Official criteria: FTC Competition Manual §6. Advancement specifics: FIRST Chesapeake. STEM4U is not affiliated with FIRST.

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